Plantain Aggregation Business Plan

Prepared for: Grainy Palace Farm Limited

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Business scope: Smallholder sourcing, aggregation and delivery of fresh plantain in Ghana

Recommendation

Start a lean, order-backed plantain aggregation service. Confirm at least one plantain buyer, its written grade and volume requirements, price basis, delivery window and payment terms before buying stock. The cocoyam off-take agreement should not be treated as a plantain commitment unless the buyer separately confirms plantain purchases in writing.

Use the first few delivery cycles to establish supplier reliability, accepted-weight loss, truck cost per tonne and the time between farmer payment and cleared buyer funds. Purchase only the volume needed for confirmed orders. Do not rent a warehouse or build a large collection operation before repeat demand is demonstrated. Plantain can face seasonal gluts and handling-related losses; the Ghana Ministry of Food and Agriculture identifies gluts between September and February as a concern. MoFA Feed Ghana Programme.

Business concept

Grainy Palace Farms will coordinate harvest-ready smallholder lots, consolidate them into buyer-sized loads, grade and weigh the fruit, and deliver it to wholesalers, market traders, food-service buyers or processors against confirmed orders. The company earns the difference between accepted sales proceeds and the full delivered cost of the purchased plantain.

The company's service is dependable volume, agreed maturity and quality, accurate weights, traceable supplier lots, and on-time delivery. The first customer should be the buyer that offers the clearest specifications and dependable payment, not necessarily the one offering the highest quoted price.

Market and product approach

Ghana's MoFA Feed Ghana Programme describes plantain as an important staple and reports a provisional 2024 national average yield of 14.51 tonnes per hectare. This production figure is context only; it is not a supply estimate for Grainy Palace Farms, and it is not used in the aggregation budget. The same report flags seasonal gluts and losses associated with handling and limited storage. MoFA Feed Ghana Programme.

Before each order, confirm the buyer's preferred variety/type, maturity stage, bunch or finger size, acceptable damage, trimming, bunch versus weight-based pricing, packaging, and delivery condition. Agree how weights are determined and how quality disputes or rejected quantities will be resolved. If the transaction is priced by bunch, convert it to a comparable accepted-weight basis using actual trial-lot weights rather than an assumed average bunch weight.

Operating model

1. Get a written buyer order or purchase schedule, with quantity, delivery point, maturity/grade, price, acceptance method and payment date.

2. Map a small first group of producing farmers. Record farm locations, expected harvest windows, estimated volume, type/variety where known, and agreed purchase terms.

3. Confirm harvest readiness and buyer order before dispatching a truck. Coordinate cutting, de-handing or other preparation only to the buyer's specification.

4. Weigh and inspect lots, record supplier and field, harvest date, gross and accepted weight, condition, agreed price and any rejection.

5. Load and transport in a way that limits compression, abrasion and exposure to avoidable damage. Keep lots identifiable through delivery.

6. Obtain buyer's signed weight and acceptance record. Resolve deductions against the agreed specification and reconcile the delivery to farmer payments and invoice.

7. Pay farmers on written, realistic terms. Maintain a cash reserve for farmer and transport obligations while buyer funds are outstanding.

Use a shaded, ventilated short-stay holding area only when needed to synchronize a confirmed delivery. Avoid speculative storage or ripening inventory until losses, buyer demand and handling requirements are measured.

Phased launch

Phase	Actions	Gate to advance
Validate demand	Secure a plantain-specific buyer specification, indicative order calendar and payment terms. Visit potential supplier communities and obtain current transport quotations.	A written, viable buyer order or credible purchase schedule and supplier lots that can meet it.
Trial deliveries	Complete several small, pre-sold deliveries. Measure accepted weight, damage/rejection, all-in logistics cost per tonne, contribution and cash days.	Positive contribution after all direct costs and no unresolved buyer/farmer payment mismatch.
Repeat service	Set regular buying days around buyer demand and supplier harvests. Add farmers and delivery frequency only as the cash cycle allows.	Repeated profitable, on-time deliveries and enough working capital to cover the next cycle.
Expand channels	Add another buyer or a processor/market channel to reduce dependence on one customer.	Written specifications, distinct receivables tracking and proven margin for each channel.

Budget and funding plan

Use the companion Excel budget to enter plantain-specific monthly tonnes, farmer purchase price, buyer price, expected grade loss, harvest/loading, transport, handling/market charges, other direct costs, monthly overhead, one-time setup costs, buyer advance/payment days and owner capital. It calculates annual contribution, a rolling working-capital estimate and the funding gap after owner capital. It deliberately contains no invented local price or cost assumptions.

Fund each cycle in this order: buyer deposit or advance against a confirmed order; buyer-arranged collection or transport where available; short supplier/logistics terms matched to buyer settlement; then a short-tenor purchase-order or receivables facility backed by the written order and delivery history. Avoid long-term debt for speculative stock. Keep setup costs separate from money reserved for farmer payments.

The workbook's working-capital figure is a planning estimate based on monthly net cash outflow and buyer payment days. Replace it with a delivery-by-delivery cash calendar when order timing, payment terms or supplier payment timing is known. The model excludes costs of cultivating plantain.

Key risks and controls

Risk	Control
No confirmed plantain outlet	Obtain a plantain-specific buyer order before procurement; treat cocoyam terms as crop-specific unless amended.
Price or demand changes, including seasonal glut	Use rolling orders, compare multiple local buyer quotations and cap procurement to confirmed demand.
Quality rejection or maturity mismatch	Written grade/maturity standard, pre-harvest check, sample inspection, recorded weights and signed acceptance.
Bruising, compression or delay	Coordinate harvest to truck arrival, protect loads, avoid long holding and track damage by route and handling step.
Supplier shortfall or side-selling	Build a diversified farmer base, confirm expected harvest regularly and pay promptly under clear terms.

Risk	Control
Working-capital shortage	Cap open receivables, seek deposits, reserve farmer/transport cash, and do not use payable funds for overhead.
Buyer concentration or delayed settlement	Set exposure limits per buyer and add a second verified channel after the first cycle is stable.

First 30 days

1. Ask existing buyer whether it purchases plantain, then obtain a separate written product specification, expected monthly volume, price basis, acceptance process, delivery responsibility and payment terms.

2. Obtain current price checks from target wholesale and market buyers, plus transport and handling quotations for likely sourcing routes.

3. Map prospective farmer suppliers and document expected harvest dates and available lots. Trial-weigh bunches if the buyer prices by bunch.

4. Complete one modest pre-sold delivery and capture all costs, rejected weight, buyer settlement days and farmer payment days.

5. Enter verified quotes into the separate plantain budget and review the low-price, higher-loss and late-payment cases before scaling.

Information needed for a lender-ready forecast

- Plantain-specific buyer order/contract, monthly tonnes, price and unit basis, maturity/grade, delivery terms, rejection and payment provisions.
- Sourcing district, farmer locations, harvest calendar, variety/type and expected volumes.
- Weighed trial-lot data and accepted weight after buyer grading.
- Farmer purchase prices, harvest/loading cost, transport quotation, handling/market fees and expected credit/advance terms.
- Monthly business overhead, setup quotations, available owner capital and proposed facility terms.

Sources and limits

The MoFA national production and seasonal-glut figures are used as market context only. They do not forecast Grainy Palace Farms' purchases, losses or returns. Local prices, order quantities, farmer availability and operating costs must be verified for the actual route and season before committing working capital. The business plan is for aggregation only and does not include plantain cultivation.